

Be**T**There

Taking the pain out of friend group meetups.

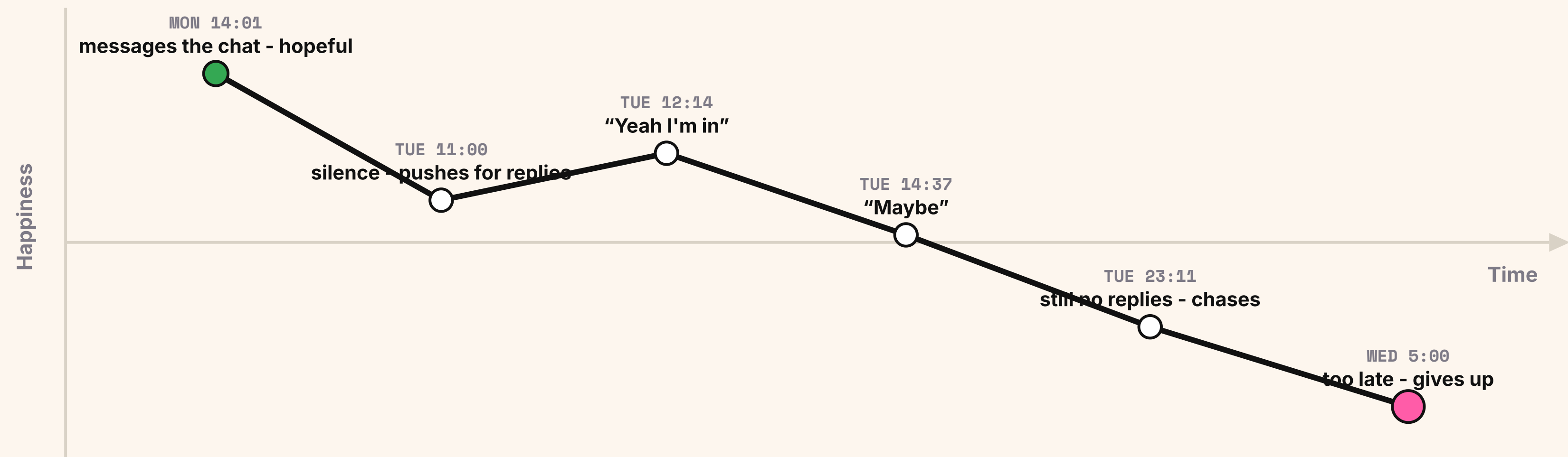
Meet **Vasanth**

- Age 21
- Studies Law at St. Andrews
- Enjoys playing volleyball and board games
- Loves to cook for his friends
- Extroverted and reliable

The **organiser**.



Vasanth's Christmas break, mapped as he felt it



THE ORGANISER'S PROBLEM

Vasanth loves to meet his friends, but organising is difficult and chasing replies from group members is frustrating.

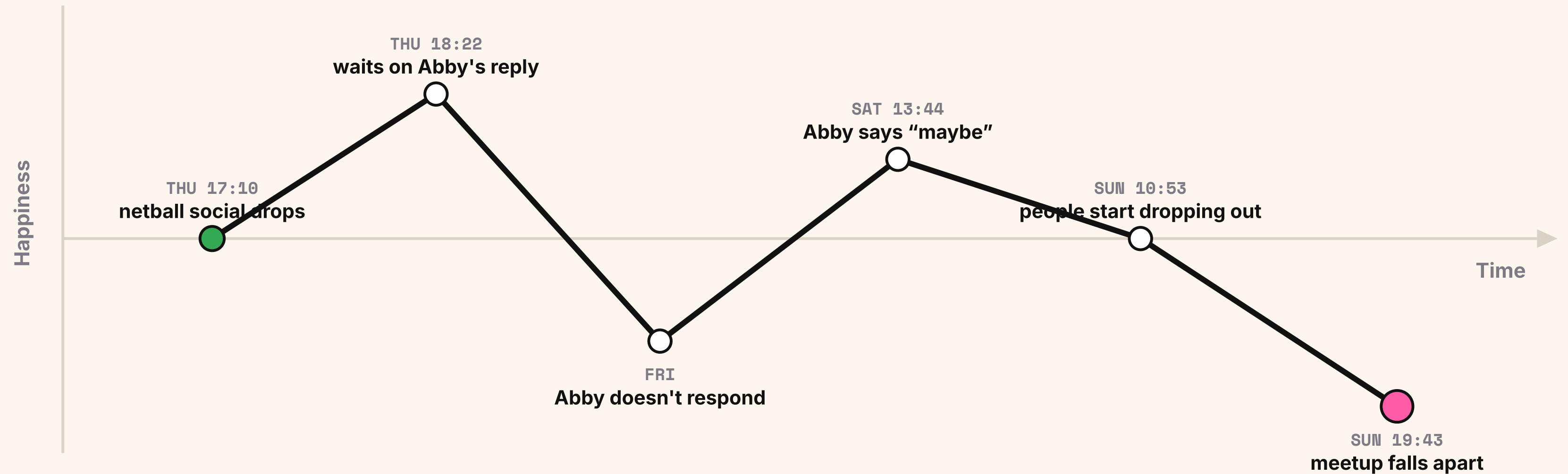
Meet **Milly**

- Age 19
- Studies English Literature at St. Andrews
- Likes to play cello and read
- Recently joined her university's netball society
- Shy and introverted

The **passive** participant.



Milly's netball social, mapped as she felt it



THE PARTICIPANT'S PROBLEM

Milly would love to engage with her netball society's socials more, but she is *hesitant* because she wants to be sure her friends are *going too*.

RESEARCH

To better understand this problem, we interviewed
university students **about their social lives.**

“

If I drummed up the plan, and it's taken **considerable time**, looking at logistics, pricing, whether everyone's okay with it, and then it falls through after all of that, that's **quite frustrating**.

Eddie, 21 - the organiser

3rd year Psychology at Goldsmiths





“

As days went past, [the meetup] got more drawn out, second thoughts crept in, and more and more people ended up **pulling out.**

Chloe, 19 - the passive participant

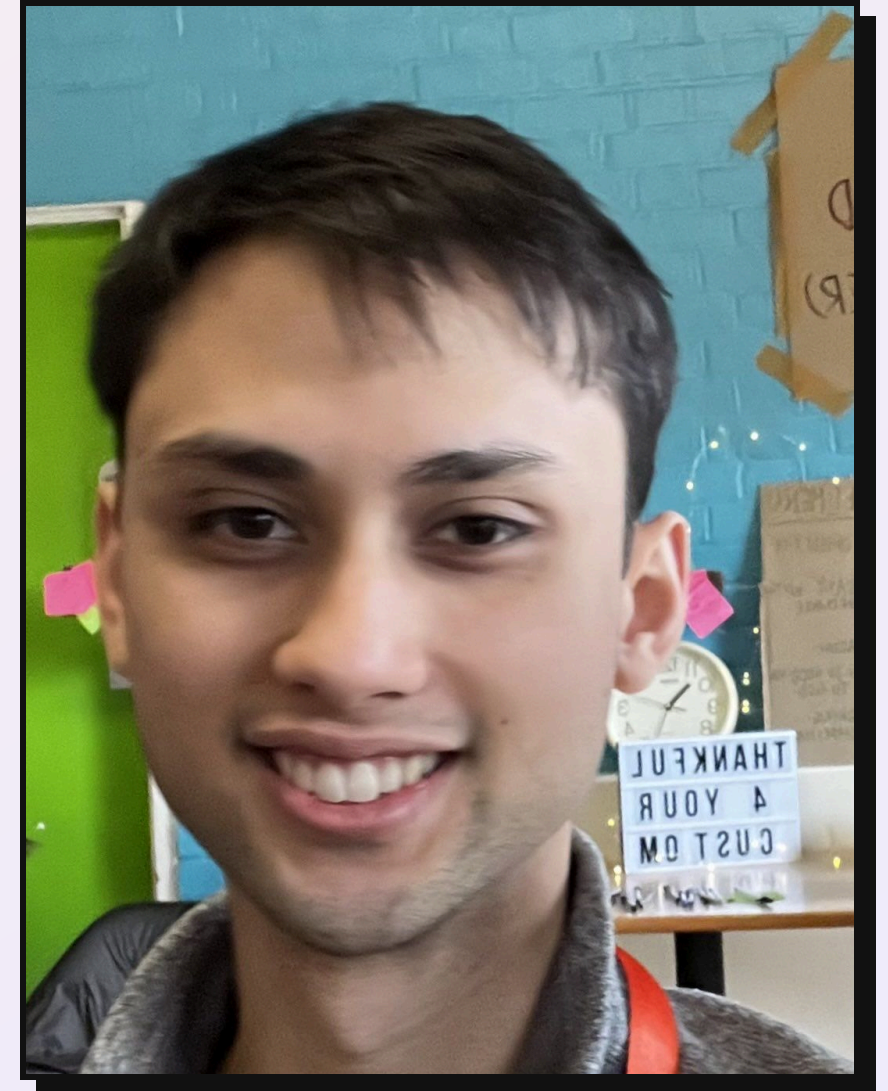
2nd Year International Relations at King's College

“

If [I'm meeting] a friend of a friend, my attendance is **conditional** on my friend being there. I'll wait for them to respond first, then decide.

Luca, 20 - the passive participant

BioChem at Oxford



Two key stakeholder **groups**

1. SUGGESTORS

One sided and exhausting. *Awkward* to push for replies.

2. PARTICIPANTS

Uncertainty *compounds* uncertainty. Some people's participation is *contingent* on others.

50%+

of our 47 survey respondents said **over a third** of meet-ups never made it out of the chat.

60%

said the meet-up time gets moved **half the time or more.**

87%

send a **maybe** or **delay** their response to a plan they are unsure about.

A DECADE AGO

7%



TODAY

22%

of young people have one or no close friends.

25%+

of lonely young people have sought therapy.

BACP, *Loneliness impacting majority of young people's mental health*,

[<https://www.bacp.co.uk/news/news-from-bacp/2025/20-june-loneliness-impacting-majority-of-young-people-s-mental-health/>]

OPPORTUNITY - HOW MIGHT WE

How might we reduce **hesitancy in university friend groups when planning to meet up so that groups go from frustrating '**maybe**' responses to a clear **consensus**?**

DEMONSTRATION

Suggesting a **meetup**

User Story

As a social member of my friend group who tends to organise things

I want to be able to easily suggest meetups to my friends

So that I can see my friends more without the frustration of chasing responses



CORE INTERACTION

Simplify suggesting a
meetup

Our Initial Design

Your meetups

T

1 ACTION REQUIRED

climbing

Glitter Natters

VOTING CLOSES
21 hours left

All

Going

Open

Done

sky diving

Climbing Group

Open

3 options

5 hours left

New meetup

MY MEETUPS

MY GROUPS

Your meetups dashboard

<

Suggest a meet

GROUP

Lithuanian Study Group

Climbing Group

TITLE

Bouldering

LOCATION

Vauxwall East

DATE

2026-06-10

TIME

14:00

Create

Meetups

Groups

Account

Suggest a meet



LIVE DEMO

Suggesting a meetup

on a real device

Added voting on **times**

20:05

<

Suggest a meet

LOCATION

optional

TenPin Bexleyheath

NOTES

optional

Come at 6, we'll eat around 8

WHEN

Flexible

Fixed

Offer a time or two; people react and it locks at a deadline.

Tomorrow eve

This Sat

Sat eve

Next week

Thu, Jun 4

10:15 PM

+ Add a time

LOCKS IN

Locks Wed 3 Jun, 22:15

the evening before - best-supported time wins

Change

Float it

Add a title to continue

Meetups

Groups

Account

Flexible vs fixed times

20:08

<

The Boys

LOCKS IN

11h 25m

best-supported time wins

Dancing

Which of these work?

Tap the times you can make - private to you.

☐

Wed 3 Jun, 19:00

☐

Sat 6 Jun, 13:00

+ Add a time

☐

I can't make it

you won't be asked again - tap a time to rejoin

Force lock now (dev)

Meetups

Groups

Account

Vote on the times that work

Feed**back**

from usability testing

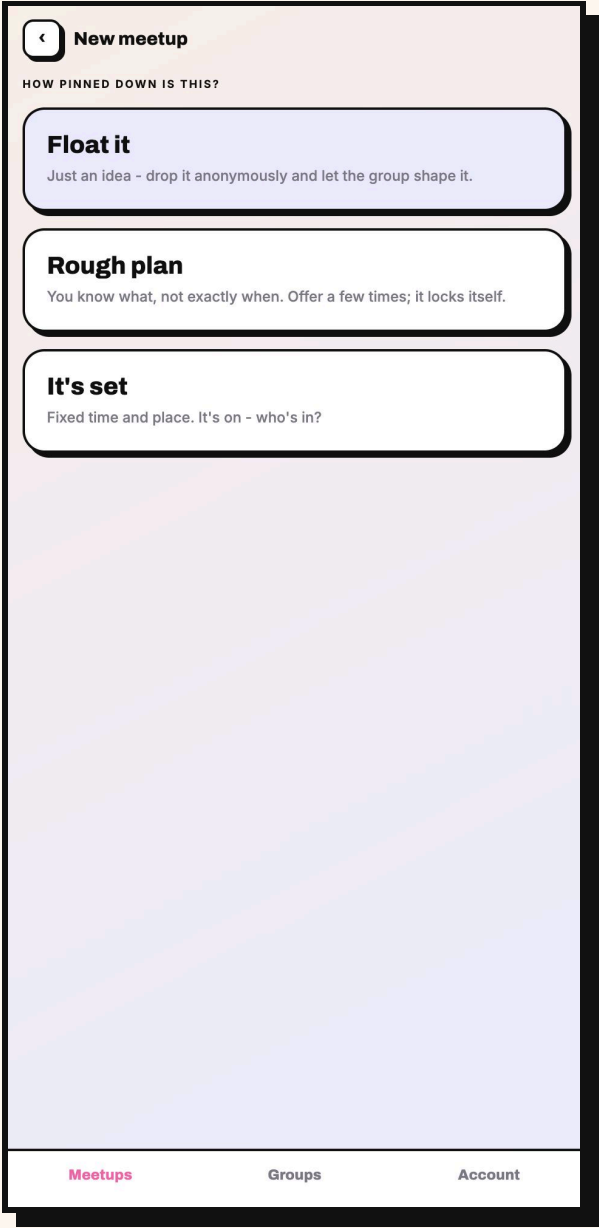
“

This form feels quite cluttered

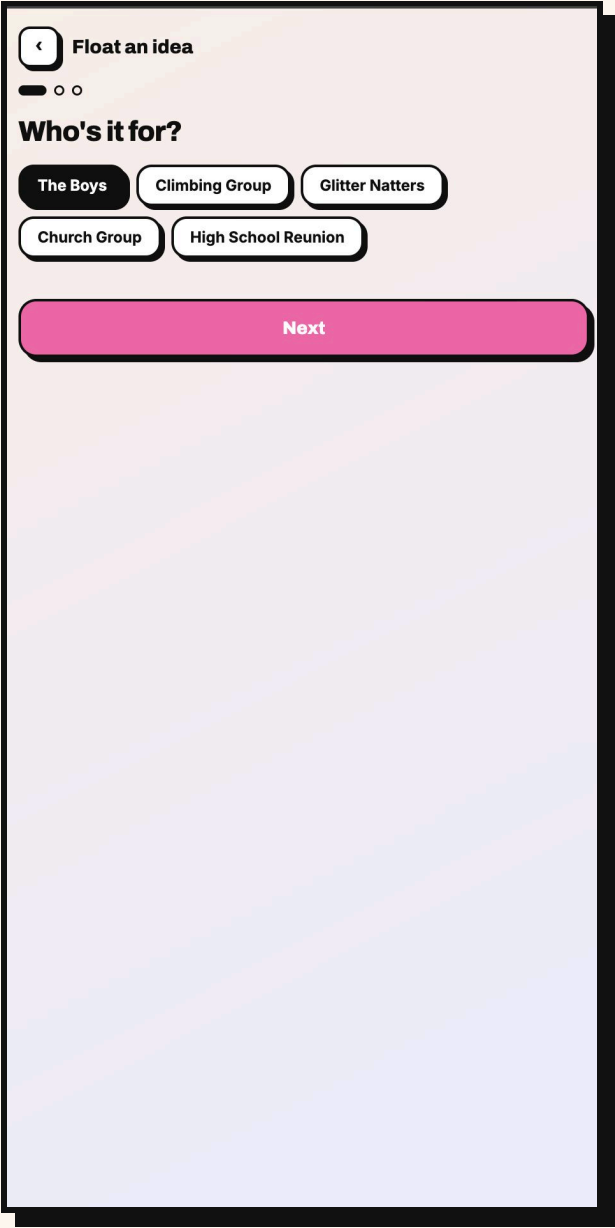
“

**It takes me a second to read
through to make sure I understand
where to put everything**

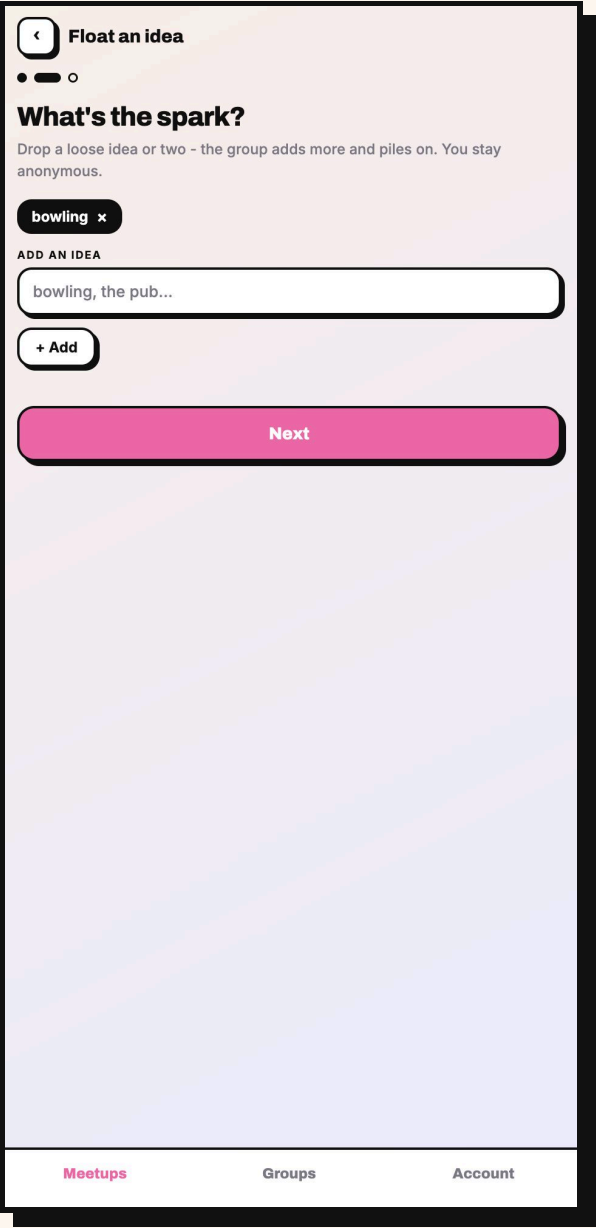
After some refinement



How pinned down?



Who's it for?



What's the spark?



Roughly when?

User Story

As a new and introverted member of a friend group

I want to only attend social events if I already know people going

So that I feel comfortable



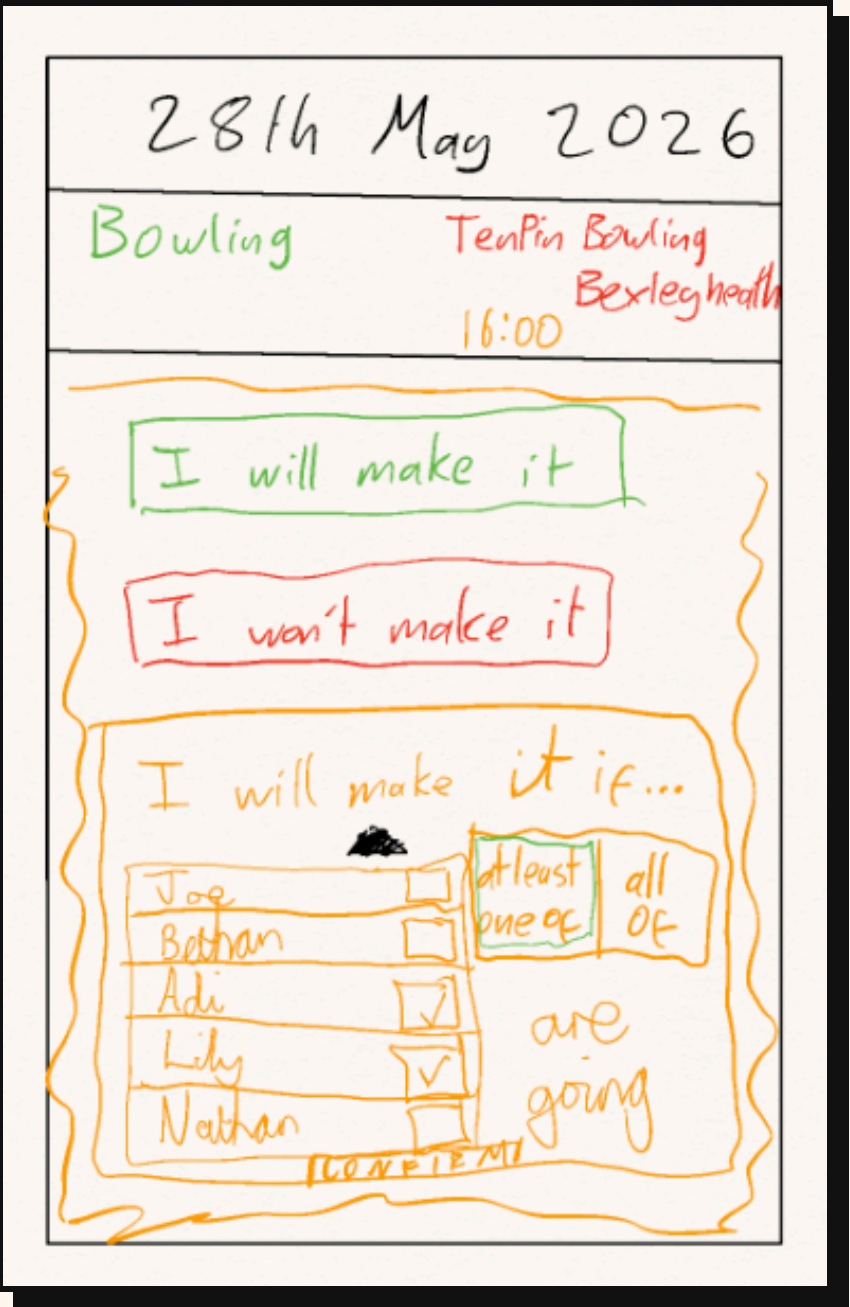
CORE INTERACTION

Conditional attendance

Initial Mock-up

The “I'll make it if [people] are going” conditional - sketched first on paper, then built.

Paper sketch



DEMONSTRATION

Conditional attendance

User **Story**

As someone wanting to organise a meetup for my friends

I don't want to have to convince people to download a new app

So that I can save time and avoid frustration



CORE INTERACTION

Onboarding new **users**

Our Initial Design

This mockup shows the 'Create a group' screen. At the top, there's a header with a back arrow and the group name 'Gamer boys'. Below this is a 'GROUP NAME' label and a text input field containing 'Gamer boys'. Underneath is a 'MEMBERS (1)' label and a member list showing 'Lukas Trakimas' with a red circular avatar containing a white 'L' and a close button. A large pink button labeled 'Invite to group' is positioned below the member list. The bottom of the screen features a navigation bar with two tabs: 'MY MEETUPS' and 'MY GROUPS', with 'MY GROUPS' being the active tab.

< Gamer boys

GROUP NAME

Gamer boys

MEMBERS (1)

L Lukas Trakimas

Invite to group

MY MEETUPS MY GROUPS

Create a group

This mockup shows the 'Invite with a join code' screen. It has the same header as the previous screen. Below the header, there's a 'GROUP NAME' label and a text input field containing 'Gamer boys'. Underneath is a 'MEMBERS (1)' label and a member list showing 'Lukas Trakimas' with a red circular avatar containing a white 'L' and a close button. A large pink button labeled 'Invite to group' is positioned below the member list. The bottom of the screen features a white modal box with the title 'Invite to group' and the subtitle 'Anyone with the code can join.' Inside the modal, there's a 'JOIN CODE' label and a text input field containing 'KT4D-4AHH' with a pink 'Copy' button. Below this is an 'INVITE LINK' label and a text input field containing 'https://bethere-dev.vercel.app/join/KT4D4AHH' with a pink 'Copy' button. A large pink button labeled 'Share invite' is positioned at the bottom of the modal.

< Gamer boys

GROUP NAME

Gamer boys

MEMBERS (1)

L Lukas Trakimas

Invite to group

Invite to group

Anyone with the code can join.

JOIN CODE

KT4D-4AHH

Copy

INVITE LINK

https://bethere-dev.vercel.app/join/KT4D4AHH

Copy

Share invite

Invite with a join code



IN HIS WORDS

Hear it from Luca

on onboarding friends

After some refinement

<

Meetup

VOTING CLOSES

5 days left

Top pick wins

The Boys

The Boys

Edit

What

+ add an activity

When

+ add a time

☐

Can't make it

Tap anything above to rejoin

No names, just the group.

Share this meetup

Anyone with the link can join and respond.

INVITE LINK

https://bethere-dev.vercel.app/m/e_d63c1c81-e2d5-4ddd-a1

Copy

Share invite

Add to a shared meetup

You're invited

TB

The Boys

Help pick a time

Join The Boys & respond

Continue as test user

No app to download.

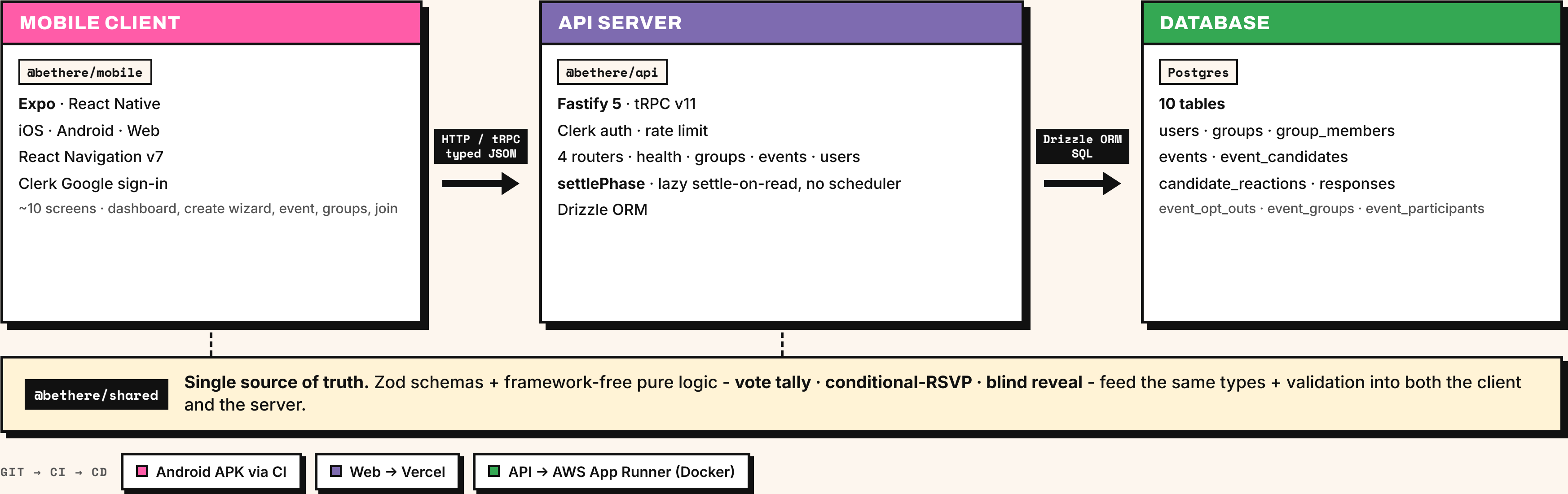
Join - no app to download

DEMONSTRATION

Onboarding new **users**

Implementation

System Architecture



Why this **stack**

TypeScript + pnpm monorepo

One language across client, server, and shared logic. Refactors are **type-checked end to end**.

tRPC v11 + Zod

A **fully type-safe API** with zero hand-written types or codegen. One schema validates server input and types the client.

Expo / React Native

One codebase ships to **iOS, Android, and web** - so we could test with real users on whatever device they already had.

Fastify 5

A lightweight, fast Node server - a thin, low-overhead host for the tRPC layer.

Postgres + Drizzle ORM

Groups, votes, and RSVPs are inherently relational, so the database gives us **integrity for free**, with typed SQL.

Clerk

Managed auth with **real Google OAuth** - we don't roll our own identity or security.

Git → GitHub Actions CI/CD

Lint, typecheck, and tests run on **every change**, with continuous deployment to AWS App Runner (API) and Vercel (web).

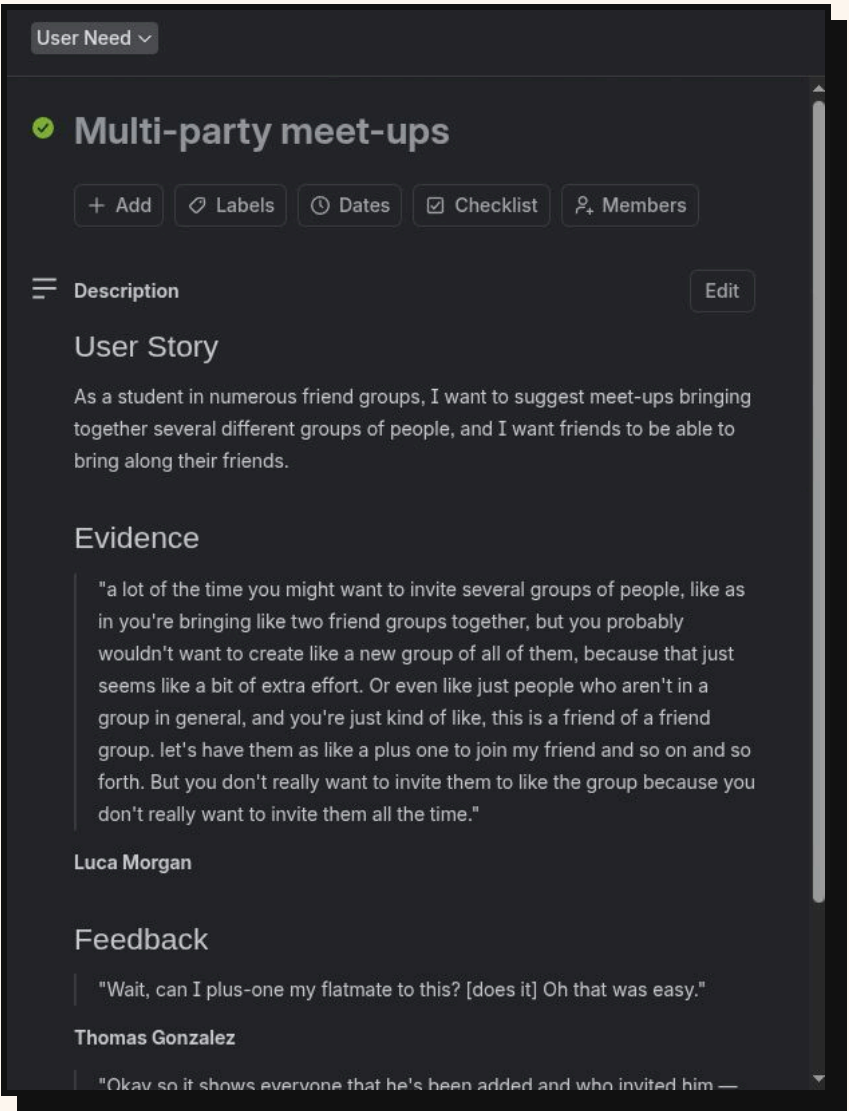
Evaluation

What went well

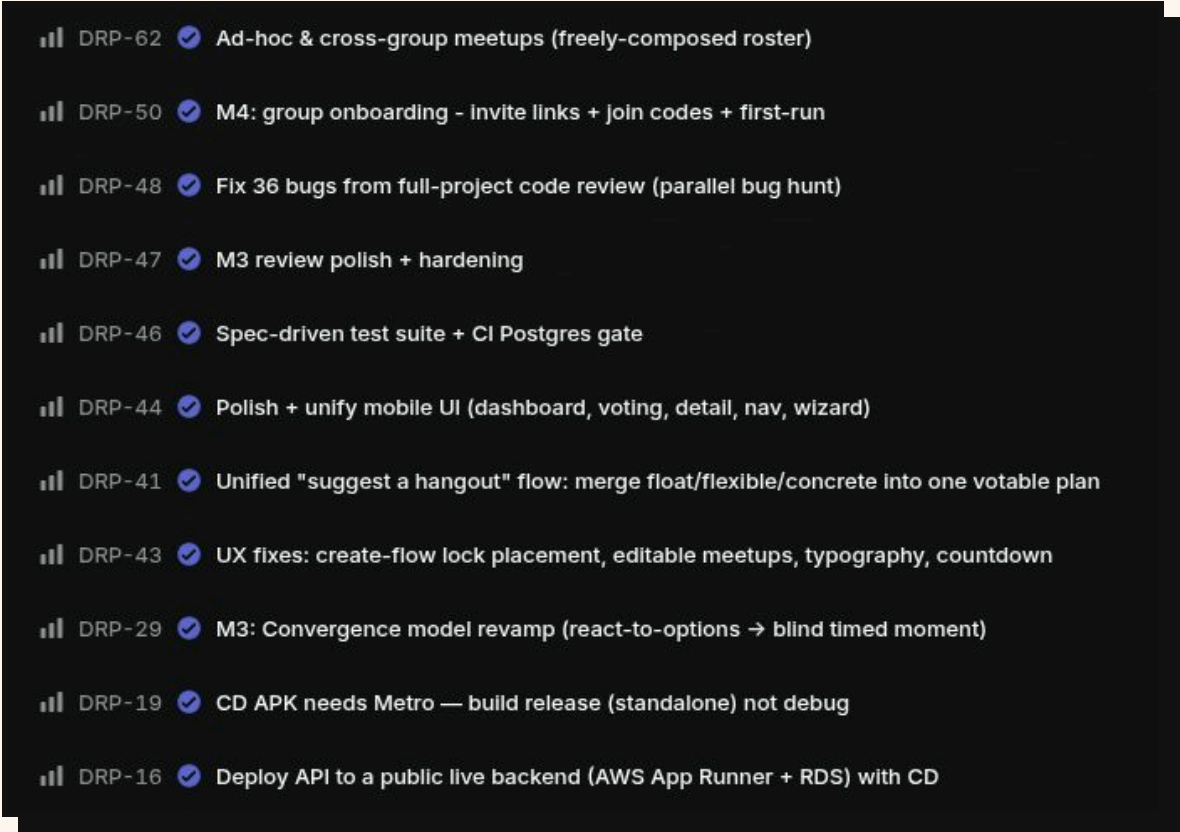
Continuous feedback from **new and **recurring** users gave us diverse insights into how the problem is actually solved.**

Letting users plan **real meetups with their friends using BeThere helped identify the pain points of the app.**

Agile development



Trello for mapping user needs.



Linear for engineering issues.

What we would do differently

Testing: a stronger test suite with wider code coverage would've prevented bugs from recurring.

Interviews: run them before building, not after - validate the need first.

Looking ahead

**Milly's availability may change after confirming
she'll BeThere**

People who will go if Milly goes want to be notified
she might not make it.

Plus-ones are still an awkward problem.

Vasanth may welcome plus-ones to his meetup, but
there are some people he would prefer not to see
there.

Meetup logistics are full of nuance - we cannot capture every case.

An in-app chat dedicated to the meetup, available after confirmation, would let the group settle the details.